

AFRICAN ADVENTURE

AUSTRALIAN WRITER Alan Moorehead traveled as a passenger in an Empire flying boat through East Africa. He recalled his exotic encounter with an undeveloped continent: "There was no flying after dark and the machine put down at some fascinating places... There were no familiar airport buildings, no advertisements, no other traffic of any kind; just this rush of muddy water as you lighted down on a river or a forest lake... On the Zambezi river... they had to run a launch up and down the water a few



minutes before the plane came to clear the hippopotami away. I remember too, with particular vividness, a little place called Malakal on the White Nile in the Sudan, where the women of the Dinka tribe... walked gravely along the riverbank and turned their heads away from the great flying boat on the water..."



GO SOUTH!

The poster above – featuring a Handley Page H.P.42, also right – advertised the Imperial Airways's services through Africa and Asia. The section through East Africa was made by flying boat.

OCEAN SURVEYOR

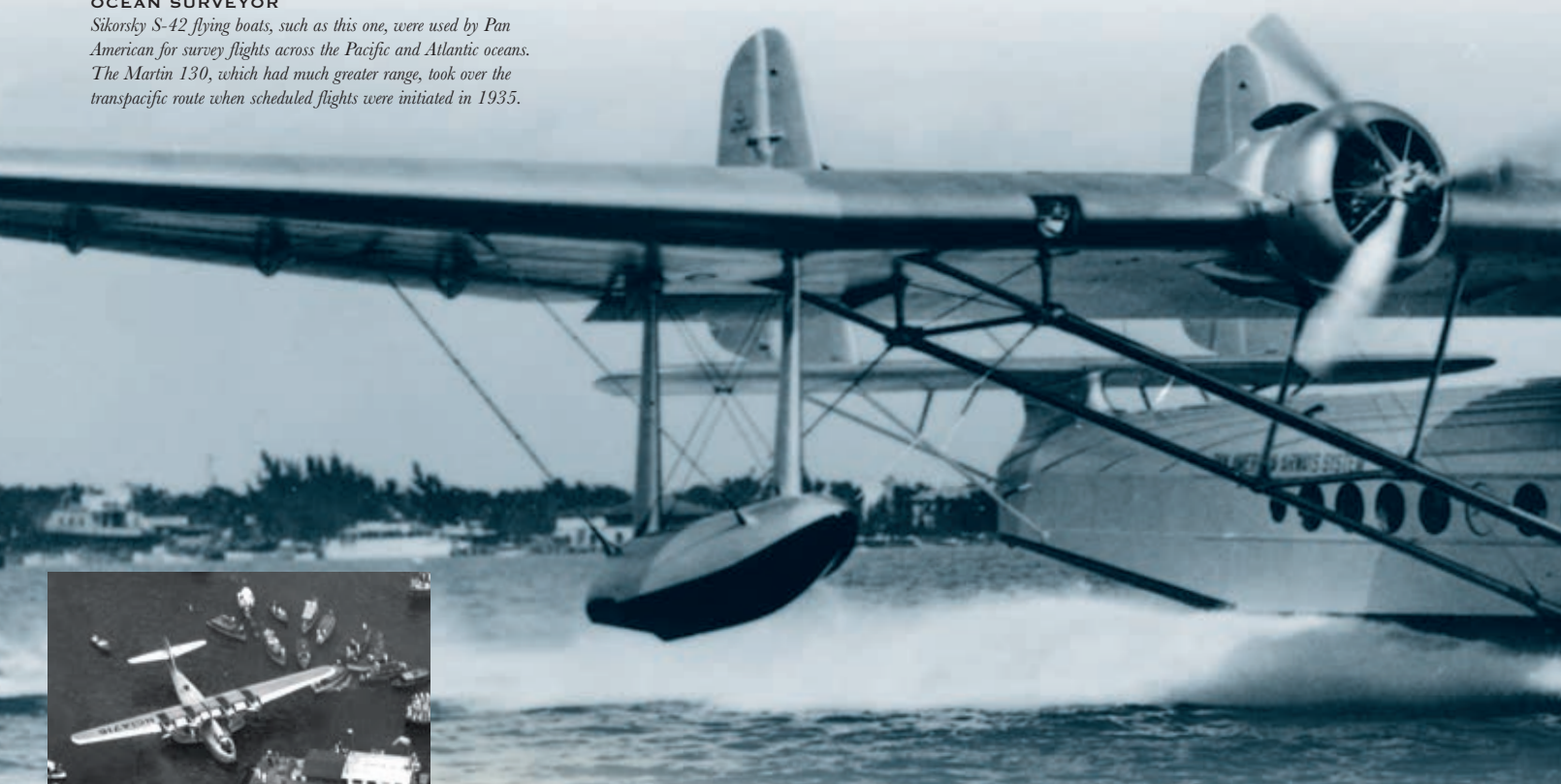
Sikorsky S-42 flying boats, such as this one, were used by Pan American for survey flights across the Pacific and Atlantic oceans. The Martin 130, which had much greater range, took over the transpacific route when scheduled flights were initiated in 1935.



Chinese province of Manchuria. Pan American had to settle for a route across the central Pacific via Hawaii and the Philippines to Hong Kong. This posed a severe technical challenge. The distance from California to Hong Kong was 7,500 miles (12,000km), including a 2,400-mile (3,900-km) stretch without landfall to Hawaii. However, no existing flying boat had that range.

Trippe ordered two powerful new flying boats: the Sikorsky S-42 to pioneer and survey the route, and the Martin 130 to follow up with scheduled services. Once again Trippe's contacts in Washington stood him in good stead. He not only won the transpacific airmail contract but also induced the government to put Wake Island under US Navy administration, so that it could act as a stepping stone for flying boats crossing the Pacific, along with Midway and Guam.

Finding these specks in the ocean was another challenge. The traditional ocean voyager's techniques of dead-reckoning and celestial navigation – using a sextant to take a fix on the sun or stars – were useful but not sufficiently reliable. Pan American's chief communications



CHINA CLIPPER

The Pan American Martin 130 China Clipper rests at a mooring station off Manila, the Philippines, after completing its first scheduled transpacific mail flight from San Francisco in November 1935.